

Dr Arunesh Kumar - Pulmonology
Sr. Consultant & Head Respiratory Medicine/Pulmonology
Paras Hospitals, Gurgaon

The lessons served by the COVID19 pandemic. And how they can help us plan a safer future.

With the world still battling the COVID19 pandemic, World Health Day assumes extra significance. The day lays emphasis on the need for equal access to healthcare facilities for all. It further serves to dispel the myths surrounding matters concerning health.

On the occasion of World Health Day Dr Arunesh Kumar, Sr Consultant, Pulmonology, Paras Hospitals, Gurugram reflects on how the two years post the coronavirus outbreak have transpired. He shares the lessons learnt from the pandemic and highlights the need for observing the prescribed protocols to protect oneself and others from COVID19 infection.

We are observing World Health Day this year amidst the COVID pandemic yet again. The last two years have taught us how an invisible enemy can bring our whole world to its knees. In India the second wave of COVID 19 was the worst by far, with many people, both young and old, losing their lives whilst a helpless medical fraternity frantically searched for an effective treatment to beat COVID. The reduced supplies of essential treatments further compounded the situation.

What COVID has also taught us is that air borne infective agents can be controlled only by contribution and active participation from everyone. With the virus constantly mutating and exhibiting different characteristics, the threat of a new wave remains looming. And thus we cannot afford to be lax in our approach.

COVID appropriate behaviour and face masks together with vaccines remain the most important way of preventing new COVID infections. Various studies have proven the effectiveness of the vaccines in protecting COVID patients from serious illness, hospitalisation and death.

A fraction of COVID patients also carry lingering symptoms following recovery, labelled as long COVID. The condition is not just restricted to older people and the ones already suffering from serious medical ailments but also impacts the young and otherwise healthy individuals. While the risk of long COVID does remain higher in those who battle severe infections, it also affects some who recover after showing mild symptoms. The most common symptoms included cough, palpitation, lightheadedness, foggy brain etc. It is important to give due attention to these issues so that one can get back to leading a normal life.

The pandemic has also resulted in an increase in the prevalence of anxiety and depression worldwide. The lockdown imposed in response to the pandemic resulted in social isolation. Consequently, financial insecurity and fear of death have played havoc on people's mental health. It has particularly taken a toll on the psychological well being of the health workers who have been found combating clinical and nonclinical stressors. In the early stages of the pandemic, it was the shortage of personal protective equipment that made headlines. As the virus load in the hospitals increased, they grappled with the fear of bringing the infection home to family members, while confronting the reality of losing colleagues to the disease. The exhaustion accompanying long work hours further served to aggravate the issue. Though the COVID cases in India are under control at the moment, the traumatic experiences that the healthcare workers were exposed to when the second wave was at its peak, continue to impact the emotional well being of many.

The only silver lining that can be drawn is how the stigma surrounding mental health issues has subsided post the arrival of the pandemic.

What we also saw was that most other diseases were ignored during this pandemic. The absence of regular monitoring and treatment resulted in these diseases reaching their advanced stages. It is important thus to shun reluctance to visit hospitals for continuing the treatment of one's other medical conditions. Those of you who are on any regular treatment should be compliant with your treatment. A good, healthy diet, exercise, and quitting smoking (if you are a smoker) are of paramount importance. Medicine is constantly evolving and the quest for new treatments for all diseases will continue.

On World Health Day, as responsible global citizens, let us pledge to adopt a healthy lifestyle and continue to follow COVID appropriate behaviour, and, most importantly, use face masks appropriately.

